

The Seventh Day and the First Covenantal Age: Bounded Cessation, the Eternal Covenant of Obedience, and the Inheritance of the Curse

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Abstract

This paper advances a unified reading of the creation account and its covenantal aftermath. It argues that the seventh *yom* of Genesis 2:2-3 marks the cessation of a specific divine work, the work of special cosmological creation, and not the cessation of divine activity as such. On the seventh day God rests from forming the cosmos while continuing to uphold it by providence and, after the Fall, to act within it by special redemptive work. This threefold distinction among cosmological creation, providence, and redemption resolves the apparent tension between Genesis 2:2-3 and John 5:17 and grounds the seventh day as the inauguration of the first covenantal age, the age of man's works and will under the sovereignty of God. Within that frame the paper construes the first covenant as a covenant of obedience rather than of merited works: a bond of obedience owed by the creature to the Creator, inaugurated at creation and holding eternally, tested in Eden, breached under the curse, satisfied by the obedience of the second Adam, and rendered perfectly by the glorified in the consummation. On this construal Hosea 6:7 is reconciled rather than merely conceded, since an eternally holding and universal obligation is attested as breached under every available rendering of the verse, including the toponymic reading favored by Andersen and Freedman. The paper then argues that what propagates from Adam to his posterity is the curse of the broken covenant together with inherited corruption, rather than the forensic imputation of Adam's personal guilt, on the grammatical-historical ground that the consecutive sense of *eph' hō* in Romans 5:12, established by Fitzmyer, underdetermines the imputation reading that the Latin *in quo* tradition built upon. The deliberately asymmetric structure of the Adam-Christ parallel in Romans 5:15-19 is shown to confirm rather than threaten this construal, and the obedience framing is shown to cohere with that asymmetry better than a merit framing does. The paper closes by reconciling the argument with the enterable rest of Hebrews 4 and the new-creation motif. Throughout, the method is grammatical-historical exegesis operating under the authority and self-interpreting priority of Scripture.

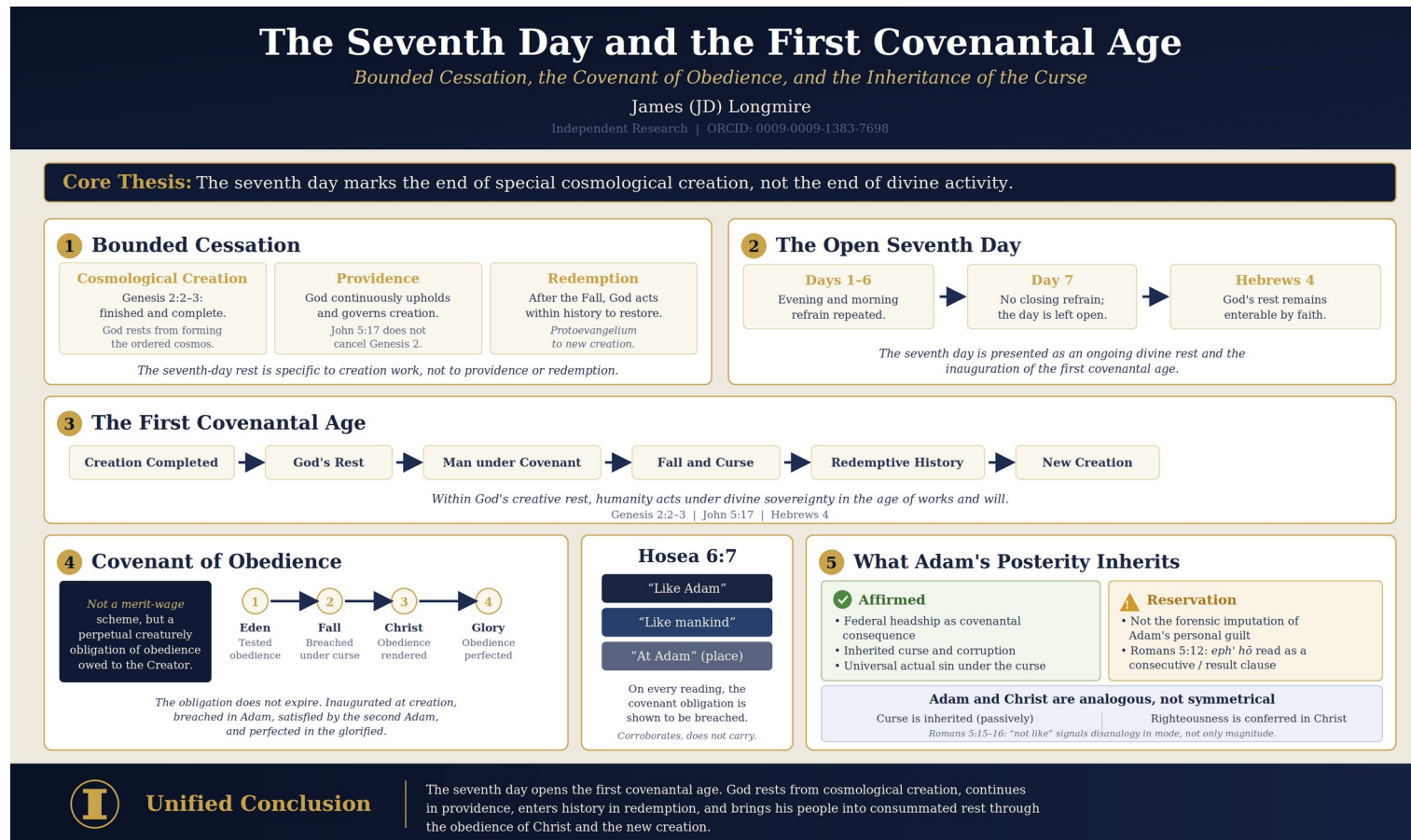


Figure 1: Summary of the argument: the seventh day as bounded cessation, the eternal covenant of obedience, and the inheritance of the curse. The diagram compresses the paper's structure and necessarily omits the nuances developed in the prose. Figure by the author.

1. Methodological Foundation

A brief declaration governs everything that follows, and it should be stated before the argument rather than assumed within it.

Scripture is the revealed Word of God to his people and the highest authority for matters of faith, reason, and practice. The first task in interpretation is to ask what the text says, what it does not say, what it authorizes us to infer, and how that reading coheres with the whole counsel of God. History, grammar, scholarship, tradition, and the natural sciences are valuable aids, but they are subordinate aids. Scripture interprets Scripture first. The Holy Spirit has curated the Word so that ordinary means may be employed to understand God's revealed truth across all ages and peoples. The governing posture is unity in first principles, charity in secondary matters, and glory to God alone above all.

This is not decorative. It does specific work at three points in the argument, and naming that work in advance answers the methodological objection a careful reader will raise.

First, it sets the order of appeal. The reading of the seventh day developed below is established by Scripture interpreting Scripture, by reading Genesis 2:2-3 together with John 5:17 and Hebrews 4, and only then corroborated by Calvin and Augustine. The tradition confirms the reading; it does not generate it.

Second, it authorizes grammatical-historical work to operate beneath scriptural authority rather than above it. When this paper prefers the consecutive sense of *eph' hō* in Romans 5:12 to the imputation reading the Vulgate's *in quo* underwrote, it does so because the Greek text bears that sense and the Latin rendering does not, which is to let a subordinate aid, philology, correct another subordinate aid, a translation tradition, with the text itself as the arbiter. The move is submission to the text, not the elevation of modern scholarship over confession.

Third, it distinguishes first principles from secondary matters in the treatment of disputed verses. The covenant of obedience is held as a first principle, grounded in the plain structure of Genesis 2 and 3. The rendering of Hosea 6:7 is a secondary matter on which charity is owed, and so the verse is allowed to corroborate but never to carry the argument.

A single methodological objection deserves a direct answer here, because it shadows the whole paper. If Genesis 1 is read with the six days as ordinary days, why is the seventh day read differently? The answer lies in the declaration's own first task, which is to ask what the text says and what it does not. The differentiated reading of the seventh day is not imposed on the text; it is signaled by the text, which withholds from the seventh day the refrain that closes each of the first six. The argument of section 3 turns on that withheld refrain. The hermeneutic is therefore consistent: the text is read literally where it speaks literally and is allowed to mark its own distinctions where it marks them.

A note on confessional posture is in order, since the argument that follows departs at two points from the strongest reading of the Westminster Standards. The position taken here is broadly confessional rather than strictly confessional. It subscribes the system of doctrine the Standards teach, including covenant theology, federal headship, the perpetual moral obligation of the creature, and the bondage of the fallen will, while registering two scoped exegetical reservations argued on *Scriptura* grounds.

The first reservation concerns the forensic construal of imputed guilt in the Westminster Confession of Faith 6.3, which this paper declines on the ground that Romans 5:12 underdetermines the imputation reading, while retaining the inherited corruption and curse the same texts plainly carry. The second concerns the framing of the first covenant. The Standards present the covenant of works as a distinct, meritorious, and probationary administration (WCF 7.2; 19.1). This paper reads its substance instead as a covenant of obedience: a bond of obedience owed by the creature to the Creator, holding eternally rather than functioning as a merit transaction superseded once broken. The command in Eden is the test of a standing obligation, not the price of a wage. This reading is held to render the Genesis structure

more faithfully than the merit framing and to cohere better with the Adam-Christ asymmetry developed in section 7. Both reservations are bounded, both are argued from the text rather than from the authority of scholarship as such, and both leave the system of covenant theology and federal headship intact. This is the historic distinction between subscribing the system a confession teaches and subscribing every proposition within it, a distinction older Reformed divinity recognized (Hodge 1871).

2. The Bounded Cessation and Its Threefold Register

The claim that God rested on the seventh day is often heard as the claim that God ceased to act. The text says less and means something more precise. What ceases is a particular work, and identifying that work resolves a tension that has occupied interpreters since the patristic period.

Three registers of divine activity must be held apart.

The first is special cosmological work: the creative activity by which God brings the kinds and the ordered cosmos into being, the *bara'* of Genesis 1. This work is finite and complete. Genesis 2:1 states that the heavens and the earth were finished, and 2:2 that on the seventh day God finished the work he had done and rested from all his work. The completion is emphatic and the rest is rest from *this* work.

The second is providence: the continuous upholding and governing of the completed order. This activity does not cease on the seventh day or on any day. Calvin states the point directly in his commentary on John 5:17, observing that God's rest is not idleness but true perfection, that God did not cease to sustain by his power the world he had made, to govern it by his wisdom, to support it by his goodness, and to regulate all things according to his pleasure in heaven and on earth, and concluding that in six days the creation of the world was completed but the administration of it is still continued (Calvin 1847). The cessation is specific; providence is continuous.

The third is special redemptive work: the immediate inbreaking acts by which God, after the Fall, restores what sin has broken. This work commences after the breach of Genesis 3 and runs through the covenantal age toward consummation. It includes the protoevangelium of Genesis 3:15, the covenants, the incarnation, the resurrection, and the inauguration of the new creation.

With these three registers distinguished, the long-standing tension between Genesis 2:2-3 and John 5:17 dissolves. In John 5:17 Jesus answers the Sabbath charge by saying that his Father is working until now, and that he himself is working. Read flatly against Genesis 2:2, the saying appears to contradict the divine rest. The resolution, already present in the tradition, is that the work Jesus defends is not cosmological but providential and redemptive. Augustine wrestled the same two texts together and distinguished God's creating what did not previously exist from God's continuing to act upon what already exists, holding that God rested from establishing new kinds of creatures while continuing to work by governing the kinds he had made, so that the rest from creation and the ongoing work are not in conflict (Augustine 1982, 4.33.51). The Sabbath rest from creation stands intact precisely because the work defended in John 5:17 belongs to a different register. It should be noted in candor that Augustine set this distinction within his own view of an instantaneous creation rather than a sequence of ordinary days, so the present argument borrows his creation-versus-administration distinction without adopting his account of the creation week.

The cessation, in short, is real and bounded. Cosmological creation is finished on the seventh day. Providence runs without interruption. Redemptive work breaks in after the Fall. None of the three collapses into the others, and the seventh day rests only from the first.

3. The Seventh Day as Covenantal Inauguration

The seventh day is marked off from the first six by the text itself, and the mark is the absence of a refrain. Each of the six creative days closes with the formula of evening and morning: there was evening and

there was morning, the first day, and so through the sixth. The seventh day carries no such closure (Genesis 2:2-3). The formula that bounds the working days is withheld from the day of rest.

This is the textual signal that licenses a differentiated reading, and it answers the charge of special pleading raised in section 1. The interpreter is not choosing to read the seventh day differently; the text presents it differently. The first six days are bounded intervals within the creative week. The seventh is left open, unbounded by the closing formula, and the canon treats it as a state still enterable rather than a completed interval. Hebrews 4:3-11 reasons from Genesis 2:2 that God's rest remains open and that a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God, which presupposes that the seventh day is not a closed twenty-four-hour unit but an ongoing divine rest into which others may enter.

The open seventh day is therefore best read as the inauguration of the first covenantal age: the age in which God, having finished his creative work and entered his rest, governs the completed order by providence while man acts within it under the terms of covenant. This is the age of man's works and will under the sovereignty of God's works and will. It begins when cosmological creation ceases, it is sustained throughout by providence, and after the Fall it becomes the theater of redemptive work.

It is worth being explicit that locating "the age of man's works and will" within the seventh-day rest does not invert the rest motif. The seventh day is precisely when divine creative work ceases, and the rest is God's. Man's works occur within the providential order God upholds during his creative rest, not in competition with it. The polarity is preserved: God rests from creating, God continues to govern, and the creature acts within the governed and completed order. Section 7 develops how this coheres with the rest that Hebrews 4 invites the believer to enter.

4. Introducing the Covenant of Obedience

The first covenant (termed the covenant of works in the Westminster tradition, though its substance is better named a covenant of obedience) is established not by a proof text but by the structure of the narrative in Genesis 2 and 3, which exhibits every formal element of a covenant.

There is a stipulated command: of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil the man shall not eat (Genesis 2:16-17). There is a probationary setting in which obedience is tested. There is a specified sanction: in the day that he eats, he shall surely die (2:17). There is an implied continuance, signified by the tree of life, access to which is barred only after the breach (3:22-24), which implies that continued access was the trajectory of obedience. And there is a federal arrangement, in that the man stands as the head whose action determines the condition of those who descend from him, a point made explicit in the New Testament treatment of Adam (Romans 5:12-19).

The substance of this covenant is best read as obedience owed rather than works merited. The merit framing construes Adam as earning a reward by the meritorious performance of works, the prelapsarian analogue to a wage. The obedience framing construes the bond as the obedience a creature owes its Creator as such: Adam does not earn life by laboring for it, but holds life by remaining in obedient relation to the One who gives it. The command is the test of that obedience, not its purchase price. This reading has textual and theological advantages developed below and in section 7, and it is the sense in which the term covenant of works is used hereafter.

So construed, the obligation holds eternally. It is inaugurated at creation and never lapses, because a creature owes obedience to its Creator in every age, before the Fall and after, within the covenantal age and in the consummation. The Fall does not dissolve the obligation; it places man in standing breach of a duty that remains in force, which is what renders the curse just, since man continues to owe what he continues to fail to render. The obligation moves through four states without expiring: tested obedience in Eden, breach under the curse, satisfied obedience in the second Adam who renders on behalf of his people what the first Adam withheld, and perfected obedience in the glorified, who render it unfailingly where it can no longer be tested but only confirmed. This perpetuity of the obligation is a recognizably

Reformed instinct, expressed in the perpetuity of the moral law and in the understanding of the consummation as confirmed rather than abolished obedience.

The Westminster Confession grounds the first covenant on this narrative structure directly (WCF 7.2), with later proof texts serving as supporting witnesses rather than as the foundation. The present account departs from the Confession only in declining the merit framing, as section 1 noted, while affirming the covenant, its federal structure, and its standing in the Genesis narrative.

This structural grounding matters for what follows. Because the covenant of obedience rests on the plain elements of the Genesis narrative and on the perpetual obligation of the creature, it does not stand or fall with any contested rendering of a single later verse. That observation governs the treatment of Hosea 6:7 in the next section. The covenant is secured upstream of the disputed text, and, as the next section shows, the eternal and universal character of the obligation allows Hosea 6:7 to corroborate it on every available reading.

5. Hosea 6:7 Reconciled on Every Reading

Hosea 6:7 reads, in the rendering of several major translations, that they, like Adam, transgressed the covenant; there they dealt faithlessly with God (so ESV, NASB, CSB; similarly NLT). The verse is frequently enlisted as direct evidence for a covenant with Adam, and on a merit-covenant reading it becomes a liability, since the merit construction needs *ke'adam* to denote a specific person whose meritorious probation types Israel's, a narrow demand the disputed Hebrew may not meet. The covenant of obedience removes that liability. Because the obligation it names is eternal and universal, the verse attests a breached covenant obligation on every available construal, and the translation dispute ceases to bear on the argument.

The Hebrew phrase *ke'adam* admits three construals. It may be read "like Adam," taking *adam* as the proper name of the first man, which yields a person-to-person comparison: Israel transgressed the covenant as Adam did. It may be read "like men" or "like mankind," taking *adam* generically, which yields a comparison to human faithlessness in general. Or it may be read "at Adam," taking *adam* as a place name, the town mentioned in Joshua 3:16, which yields a geographic reference to a specific covenant violation.

On the covenant of obedience, each reading testifies to the same obligation and its breach.

The personal reading, "like Adam," states that Israel transgressed the eternal obligation as the first man transgressed it at its head. The strongest philological support for this reading is Job 31:33, where *ke'adam* is used of concealing transgression as Adam did, an unambiguous reference to the first man covering his sin, which establishes that the construction can carry the personal sense.

The generic reading, "like mankind," was fatal to the merit reading because it flattened the comparison to a truism, Israel sinning as humans sin. On the covenant of obedience it is no truism but a substantive witness, for the standing obligation just is the obedience every creature perpetually owes, so that to say Israel transgressed the covenant as mankind characteristically does is to affirm the universal creaturely obligation and its perennial breach. The reading that most embarrassed the merit construction positively serves the obedience construction.

The toponymic reading, "at Adam," favored by the leading critical authority, is the one that appeared most threatening and in fact threatens nothing. Andersen and Freedman, in the Anchor Bible commentary, argue on structural grounds that verses 7 through 9 form a unit in which each member names a place, with Adam in verse 7, Gilead in verse 8, and Shechem in verse 9, and that the adverb *šām*, "there," in 6:7b points to a geographic referent (Andersen and Freedman 1980). The Hermeneia commentary likewise takes *šām* to weigh toward a place (Wolff 1974). Grant the toponym entirely. The verse then locates an instance in which the covenant was transgressed at a particular place, which presupposes rather than denies a covenant capable of being transgressed there. The breach-event is

located; the obligation breached is untouched, because the obligation is established at creation, not at Hosea.

The honest conclusion reverses the posture of mere concession. Andersen and Freedman may be entirely correct about the toponym, and the covenant of obedience is confirmed regardless, since an eternally holding and universal obligation is attested as breached under the personal, the generic, and the toponymic readings alike. The citation of the leading contrary scholarship is retained here not as a concession of ground but as a demonstration that the ground cannot be taken: even the reading most hostile to a personal-Adam covenant leaves the obedience obligation and its breach intact.

One precision keeps the claim no stronger than the texts allow. What every reading of Hosea 6:7 corroborates is the existence and breach of the covenant obligation. What no reading of the verse establishes on its own is the federal dimension specifically, that Adam's breach binds his posterity. That dimension rests on the Genesis structure and on Romans 5, treated next, not on Hosea. Hosea corroborates the obligation; Romans 5 carries the federal headship.

6. Federal Headship and the Inheritance of the Curse

The question of this section is not whether Adam's transgression had covenantal consequences for his posterity, which the narrative settles, but what precisely propagates from Adam to his line. The position argued here is that what is inherited is the curse of the broken covenant, together with the corruption of nature that issues in actual sin, rather than the forensic imputation of Adam's personal guilt.

Two claims must be separated that are often bundled together. The first is that Adam's acts carried covenantal consequence: he stood in covenant, his transgression incurred the stipulated sanction, and the effects of that sanction propagated to those he headed. This is federal headship in the broad sense, and it is not in dispute here. The second is the specific Augustinian-forensic mechanism by which Adam's guilt, his *reatus*, is imputed to each descendant as though personally charged with his act. This paper affirms the first and registers a scoped reservation against the second.

What is inherited, on the present reading, is the cursed order itself: mortality, toil, a creation subjected to futility (Romans 8:20), exile from the tree of life, and a nature bent away from God that expresses itself in each person's own actual sin. Condemnation follows, but it follows from the cursed condition and the actual sin that issues from it, rather than from a charged guilt for Adam's personal act transferred prior to any act of one's own.

The grammatical-historical case turns on the disputed phrase *eph' hō* in Romans 5:12, where Paul writes that death spread to all men, *eph' hō* all sinned. The imputation reading depends on rendering this "in whom," with Adam as the antecedent, so that all sinned in Adam. That rendering descends from the Vulgate's *in quo*, and it was on the Latin that Augustine built the inherited-guilt construction (Meyendorff 1983, p. 144). The Greek does not support it. The phrase is a contraction of the preposition *epi* with the relative pronoun, and the weight of modern scholarship across confessional lines takes it to mean "because" or, more precisely still, to function consecutively.

Fitzmyer's dedicated study is decisive on the grammatical point. In a 1993 article in *New Testament Studies*, drawing on a systematic search of Greek usage, he argues that *eph' hō* in Romans 5:12 carries a consecutive sense, best rendered "with the result that," so that the clause reads, and so death spread to all men, with the result that all sinned (Fitzmyer 1993a). Schreiner adopts the result-clause construal, translating the phrase "on the basis of which" and rendering 5:12cd to the effect that death spread to all and, on the basis of that death, all sinned (Schreiner 1998). On this reading Adam's breach is the originating cause whose result is universal death and the universal sinning that follows from it, which is the inheritance-of-the-curse structure rather than the imputation-of-guilt structure. The consecutive sense does not merely permit the curse reading; it fits it more naturally than the forensic reading, because it makes death the inherited condition out of which sin universally arises.

Intellectual honesty requires noting that Schreiner himself deploys the same grammar toward a different end. He takes the result clause to show that all enter the world spiritually dead through union with Adam and so sin individually, and he marshals the verse in support of the traditional doctrine of original sin and original death, a conclusion nearer the position this paper declines than the one it holds. Schreiner is therefore cited here for the grammatical construal of *eph' hō*, which he establishes alongside Fitzmyer, and not as an ally of the curse-not-guilt reading. The point stands that the consecutive grammar is available and well-attested; what one builds upon it is a further and separable question, and the present argument builds the inheritance of the curse where Schreiner builds union-grounded original sin. The Eastern reading represented by Meyendorff, which takes the same Greek to deny inherited guilt while affirming inherited mortality and corruption, stands closer to the construal defended here, though it is reached on different dogmatic grounds and is not adopted wholesale.

This is the scoped reservation against WCF 6.3 announced in section 1. The Confession holds that the guilt of Adam's first sin was imputed to all his posterity descending from him by ordinary generation. The present argument declines that clause's forensic construal of imputed guilt, on the exegetical ground that Romans 5:12 underdetermines it, while retaining the corruption and the curse that the Confession also teaches and that the same texts plainly carry. The reservation is bounded, it is argued from the text, and it leaves the system of covenant theology and federal headship intact.

7. The Asymmetry of the Adam-Christ Parallel

A natural objection to the foregoing is that Romans 5 trades on a symmetry between Adam and Christ, so that if Adam's side is imputed guilt, Christ's side is imputed righteousness, and to deny imputation on the one side damages the structure on the other. The objection has force only if the parallel is symmetric, and Paul is at pains to insist that it is not.

Twice in the passage Paul breaks the parallel he has drawn. The free gift is not like the trespass (Romans 5:15), and the gift is not like the effect of the one man's sin (5:16). Having set Adam and Christ in parallel, he immediately marks the disanalogy and intensifies the gift side with the refrain "much more." The two are analogous in structure, one man with consequences for many, but they are not equivalent in mode.

The disanalogy runs precisely along the seam this paper has drawn. The curse is inherited passively and naturally, propagated by ordinary generation into a condition no descendant chooses or enacts. Righteousness is not inherited in that way. No one is born justified, and righteousness does not propagate by generation into a state one is simply born into. It comes by union with Christ, received through faith, conferred as grace appropriated rather than as a condition of birth. One is brought into the second Adam; one is not born into him. The inheritance of the curse is passive; the reception of righteousness is, in the order of application, active in a way the curse never was.

The covenant of obedience sharpens this asymmetry where a merit framing would blunt it. If the first covenant were a merit transaction, the parallel would pull toward symmetric merit: Adam fails to earn life, Christ earns it, and the earned righteousness is imputed as a wage, which makes the two sides alike in kind and invites exactly the symmetric-imputation reading this section resists. On the obedience framing the two sides refer to one and the same eternal obligation rather than to a wage economy. Adam breaches the obedience owed; Christ renders the obedience owed, the perfect obedience the first Adam withheld; and the believer receives the fruit of that rendered obedience by union, not by the transfer of a merit Adam failed to accumulate. There is one obligation across both sides, breached by the one and satisfied by the other, which is why the curse can be inherited while righteousness is conferred. The eternal holding of the obligation is what unifies the two sides without making them symmetric transfers: a single perpetual debt of obedience, defaulted in Adam and discharged in Christ.

This asymmetry confirms the construal of section 6 rather than threatening it. If Adam's side were strict imputed guilt and Christ's side strict imputed righteousness, the two would be symmetric forensic

transfers, and one would indeed "fall into" righteousness in the same passive manner one fell under the curse. That is exactly what Paul's "not like" denies. The fact that the second half is not passive, not by generation, and not automatic is itself evidence that the first half need not be construed as imputed guilt by generation. A symmetric-imputation reading has to explain away Paul's repeated insistence that the two sides are unlike; the curse-and-conferral reading predicts that insistence.

Honesty requires naming the strongest form of the counterargument. A defender of symmetric imputation will argue that Paul's "much more" marks magnitude rather than mode, so that the asymmetry is one of degree, the gift exceeding the damage in superabundance, while both sides remain forensic transfers of the same kind. On this reading the two sides are alike in mechanism and unlike only in extent. The reply is that the "not like" of verses 15 and 16 is not naturally read as a claim about magnitude alone. Paul does not say the gift is merely greater than the trespass; he says it is not like it, and then specifies disanalogies in operation, the gift bringing justification out of many trespasses where the judgment brought condemnation out of one (5:16). The difference he draws is in how the two work, not only in how much. The magnitude reading must treat "not like" as hyperbole for "much greater," whereas the mode reading takes it at face value. The mode reading is therefore preferable, though the point is acknowledged as one where a careful interlocutor will press.

A second objection must be met, because it presses on the coherence of the argument's two halves rather than on the asymmetry. Section 6 rests federal headship on Romans 5, and the same critical scholarship that supplies the consecutive reading of *eph' hō* often resists the federal reading of the chapter, taking 5:12 to teach only that each person dies on account of individual sin. If the consecutive grammar were tied to that individualist conclusion, the argument would be incoherent, drawing federal headship from a verse it had just read in a non-federal way. It is not so tied, and the two halves are consistent. The consecutive construal settles only the local syntax of 5:12cd, namely that death spreads and, as its result, all sin. It does not by itself decide whether the death that spreads is grounded in Adam's representative act or merely coincident with a universal tendency to sin. That further question is answered not by the conjunction *eph' hō* but by the sustained one-man-to-many structure of 5:15-19, where Paul states six times that the condemnation, the death, and the reign of death came through the trespass of *the one man*, and that the many were constituted sinners through one man's disobedience (5:19). The federal claim rests on that repeated "through the one," which no construal of *eph' hō* touches. Indeed the consecutive reading strengthens rather than weakens the federal structure, because it makes the universal death that 5:15-19 traces to Adam the very condition out of which the universal sinning of 5:12 results, so that Adam's one act stands as the originating cause and individual sins as its downstream effect. The grammar that this paper borrows from the critical stream is therefore detachable from the individualist theology some of that stream attaches to it. One may take the syntax and decline the conclusion, and the federal reading of 5:15-19 supplies independent and stronger ground for headship than 5:12 alone could bear.

8. Resolution: The Enterable Rest and the New Creation

It remains to show that "the age of man's works and will" coheres with the rest that Hebrews 4 invites the believer to enter, and that the whole structure terminates in the new creation.

The rest of Hebrews 4 is rest from works, a ceasing from one's own labors in the manner that God ceased from his (Hebrews 4:10). This is intelligible only if God's creative work is genuinely finished and stands complete as a rest into which others may enter. The bounded cessation of section 2 is the precondition for the enterable rest: because cosmological creation is truly over, there is a divine rest with an open door. The believer's entering that rest is a ceasing from works-as-self-justification and an entrance into God's completed provision. There is no tension with the age of man's works and will, because that age is lived within the providential order during God's creative rest, and the rest the believer enters is the same divine rest, now opened through redemptive work.

The redemptive register named in section 2 is itself a creative category, which closes the structure. Paul calls the one in Christ a new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17), and the prophets speak of God creating new heavens and a new earth (Isaiah 65:17), using the same verb of creation that Genesis 1 employs. The pattern is therefore complete and coherent. Cosmological creation is finished and God enters his rest on the seventh day. The Fall introduces the rupture. Redemptive work, which is the second creative work, breaks in to restore what was broken and runs through the covenantal age. It culminates in the new heavens and new earth, the consummation of the rest the seventh day opened. The covenantal age sits in the seam: after cosmological cessation, within the unfolding redemptive work, under providence throughout.

The seventh *yom*, then, rests from cosmological creation; the age of man's works and will runs under providence; redemptive work inbreaks within it toward the new creation; and the rest of God, opened on the seventh day and entered by faith, is consummated when the second creation is complete. The eternal obligation of obedience runs through the whole as the creaturely constant: tested in Eden, breached under the curse, satisfied in the second Adam, and in the new creation rendered perfectly and unfailingly by the glorified, who rest in the obedience they now offer without the possibility of failure. The consummation is therefore confirmed obedience rather than abolished obligation, which is itself a form of the rest: not the cessation of the creature's obedience but its perfection. The account is unified, it is anchored in Genesis 2:2-3, John 5:17, Hebrews 4, and the new-creation texts, and it preserves the divine rest without making it idleness.

9. Conclusion

The seventh day marks the cessation of special cosmological creation, not the cessation of divine activity, and so inaugurates the first covenantal age, an order God upholds by providence and, after the Fall, enters by redemptive work. The first covenant is best read as a covenant of obedience rather than of merited works: a bond of obedience owed by the creature to the Creator, holding eternally, secured by the structure of Genesis 2 and 3 and by the perpetual obligation of the creature. So construed, Hosea 6:7 is reconciled rather than merely conceded, since an eternal and universal obligation is attested as breached under the personal, the generic, and the toponymic readings alike, the toponymic reading of Andersen and Freedman included. What propagates from Adam is the curse of the broken covenant and the corruption of nature that issues in actual sin, rather than the forensic imputation of his personal guilt, a reading supported by the consecutive sense of *eph' hō* that Fitzmyer established and that the Latin imputation tradition could not claim from the Greek. The asymmetry of the Adam-Christ parallel, far from requiring symmetric imputation, confirms that the curse is inherited while righteousness is conferred, and the obedience framing accounts for that asymmetry better than a merit framing can, since one eternal obligation is defaulted in Adam and discharged in Christ. The whole coheres with the enterable rest of Hebrews 4 and terminates in the new creation, where the obligation is rendered perfectly and the rest is consummated as confirmed obedience.

The argument is offered in the posture the opening declaration named: under the authority of Scripture, with grammatical and historical scholarship serving as subordinate aids, holding firmly to the covenant and its federal structure as first principles and exercising charity on the secondary matters where the text leaves room. Two scoped reservations against the Westminster Standards are owned rather than smoothed, the forensic construal of imputed guilt and the merit framing of the first covenant, both argued from the text and both leaving the system intact. *Scriptura sola, natura subdita, soli Deo gloria.*

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